Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Competitive Landscape & Moat Analysis

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

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What Is This Skill?

The Competitive Landscape & Moat Analysis skill is an AI-powered framework that helps you answer the two hardest questions in any investor pitch: Who else is doing this? And why won't someone just copy you?

It does far more than list your competitors. It maps four types of competition most founders miss, identifies which moat types you're building (or could build), scores your defensibility honestly, and prepares you for the exact pushback investors will give.

The skill works as a structured conversation. You describe your product, customer, and market. It guides you through competitor discovery, positioning analysis, moat identification, and investor readiness scoring. No spreadsheets, no MBA frameworks to learn, no guesswork.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE

Every competitor, feature claim, and moat assessment must come from you or from a web search the skill shows you before using. The skill never invents competitors or assumes advantages.

That's what makes the analysis investor-grade.

By the end of one conversation (about 30 minutes), you will have a complete competitive map showing who you're really up against, your positioning gaps and advantages, scored moat types with evidence, and a readiness check for the three questions every investor asks.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for founders who have validated their problem and market size and are now ready to articulate their competitive position before raising capital, before scaling go-to-market, and before making long-term strategic bets. It is especially useful if:

- You've validated your problem (Skill 1) and sized your market (Skill 2) and need to map the competition
- You're preparing for investor conversations and keep getting asked about competitors and moats
- You're building in a crowded space and need clarity on how you're different
- You believe you have "no competitors" and want to pressure-test that claim
- You've been told "this can be easily copied" and want to identify defensible moats
- You're a first-time founder unfamiliar with competitive analysis or moat frameworks

This skill works for founders anywhere in the world. Whether you are in Lagos, Dubai, Bangalore, São Paulo, or San Francisco, the framework adapts to your market context and competitive dynamics.

How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Competitive Landscape & Moat Analysis skill installed, and a clear description of what you're building and who for.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That's it.

Step 2: Describe Your Product and Market

Tell Claude what your product does, who your customer is, and where you're operating. If you already know some competitors, mention them. If you don't, that's fine — the skill will help you discover them.

Examples of Great Starting Messages:

EXAMPLE 1: Detailed

"I'm building payroll software for SMBs in Nigeria. My main competitors are Workpay and Seamless HR, but most businesses still use Excel. I'm focused on being 10x easier to set up than the competition — onboarding in under 5 minutes vs. 2 hours."

EXAMPLE 2: Brief

"Project management tool for remote design teams. Competitors are Asana, Monday.com, and ClickUp, but we're focused on async design feedback workflows they don't handle well."

EXAMPLE 3: Minimal

"Logistics software for e-commerce brands in Southeast Asia. I honestly don't know who my direct competitors are yet."

These three will all be effective. Your competitive map will be created more quickly if you include more information. However, even a brief explanation suffices; the tool will inquire about any gaps and assist you in jointly researching competitors.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill guides you through six phases. You don't need to prepare anything in advance or remember any frameworks. Just respond naturally to the questions. The whole process takes about 30 minutes.

What Happens: The Six Phases

The skill walks you through six phases, each building on the last. Here's what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 1: CONTEXT GATHERING *Your product, customer, and geography locked in • ~2 minutes*	
What You Do	• Describe your product in one sentence (the problem it solves) • Name your target customer and where you're operating • Mention any competitors you already know about
What You Get	• Your business restated clearly in founder language • Confirmation of what the skill already knows vs. what it still needs • A fast-path check: if you already have product, customer, and competitors clear, you skip straight to landscape mapping

WHY THIS MATTERS:
The skill never asks for information you've already provided. If your product description, customer type, or geography appears anywhere in the conversation, it carries that forward without asking again. This keeps the process fast and respectful of your time.

PHASE 2: COMPETITOR DISCOVERY & MAPPING *Finding all four types of competition • ~8 minutes*	
What You Do	• Share any competitors you already know • Review web search results the skill finds and confirm which are actually relevant • Help categorize each competitor (direct, indirect, substitute, or potential entrant)
What You Get	• A complete competitive landscape map across all four competitor types • Intelligence on each competitor: what they do, who they serve, pricing, strengths, and weaknesses • Your positioning on two key dimensions that matter to customers • Finding whitespace opportunities and gaps where there are no significant competitors

PHASE 3: MOAT IDENTIFICATION *Understanding which moat types you're building • ~5 minutes*	
What You Do	• Answer questions about customer behavior, data you collect, switching costs, and network effects • Identify which of the seven moat types apply to your business (even if early-stage) • Provide evidence or examples of each moat in action
What You Get	• Clear explanation of the seven moat types (Network Effects, Data, Switching Costs, Brand, Supply/Distribution, Workflow Lock-In, Efficient Scale) • Identification of which moats you're building and which you're not • Honest assessment of moat maturity (early, developing, or strong)

PHASE 4: MOAT STRENGTH SCORING *Rating each moat on a 1–5 scale with evidence • ~5 minutes*	
What You Do	• Provide specific evidence for each moat you claim (data, customer behavior, contracts) • Confirm the skill's scoring and adjust if the assessment doesn't match your experience • Be honest about how early-stage each moat currently is
What You Get	• A 1–5 score for each moat (1=Claimed, 2=Early, 3=Developing, 4=Strong, 5=Structural) • Plain-English explanation of what each score means for your business • Specific actions to strengthen each moat over the next 6–12 months

PHASE 5: INVESTOR READINESS CHECK *Testing your answers to the three investor questions • ~3 minutes*	
What You Do	• Review how you'd answer "Who else is doing this?" • Review how you'd answer "Why won't someone copy you?" • Review how you'd answer "What's your unfair advantage?"
What You Get	• A ✅/⚠️/❌ readiness score for each of the three questions • Specific gaps to address before your next investor conversation • Concrete next steps to strengthen the weakest areas

PHASE 6: FULL SUMMARY + NEXT STEPS *Your complete competitive picture in one view • ~5 minutes to read*	
What You Do	• Review the complete summary for accuracy • Save or screenshot the output for your pitch deck or strategy docs • Commit to the top 2–3 recommended next steps
What You Get	• The complete competitive landscape (all four types listed with positioning) • Your moat analysis with scores, evidence, and risks • Investor readiness assessment across all three questions • Recommended next steps prioritized by impact • Plain-English summary of your competitive position and defensibility

Understanding Your Results

The Four Competitor Types and What They Actually Mean

Most founders only track direct competitors. But investors ask about all four types and each one reveals something different about your market position and long-term defensibility.

Type	Definition	Why It Matters
Direct	Same problem, same customer, similar approach	These are the obvious comparisons investors will make
Indirect	Same problem, but different approach or customer segment	Often underestimated can evolve into direct competitors over time
Substitutes	Different product, but satisfies the same underlying need	This is what customers do TODAY before your product exists
Potential Entrants	Large players who could enter your space if it gets attractive enough	The “what if Google builds this?” threat critical for defensibility

The Seven Moat Types

A moat is more than just a feature or an advantage; it is a structural advantage that makes you difficult to displace. The ability recognizes seven various types of moats, each with unique building timetables and strengths.

Moat Type	What It Means	The Test
Network Effects	The product becomes more valuable as more people use it	Does each new user make the product better for existing users?

Data Moat	You accumulate proprietary data that improves your product and can't be replicated	Could a well-funded competitor with zero customers build an equally good product?
Switching Costs	It's expensive, time-consuming, or risky for customers to leave you	Has a customer ever tried to leave? What happened? How long would migration take?
Brand	Your name is synonymous with a category or customers trust you more than alternatives	Do customers choose you BECAUSE of your name, or despite never having heard of you?
Supply/Distribution	You control unique supply, distribution channels, or partnerships competitors can't access	Can a new competitor access the same suppliers or channels you use?
Workflow Lock-In	Your product becomes embedded in daily operations, making removal disruptive	If you disappeared tomorrow, how many hours would it take the customer to replace you?
Efficient Scale	There can only be one or two profitable players in the market, therefore being at the top makes you practically unbeatable.	Is the market large enough for two well-funded competitors to both be profitable?

The Moat Scoring System

The skill scores each moat on a 1–5 scale based on how defensible it is today not how strong it might become in the future.

Score	Label	What It Means
5	**Structural**	Legally, technically, or economically very hard to replicate
4	**Strong**	Requires significant time, capital, or data to match
3	**Developing**	Real advantage today, but could be closed within 2–3 years
2	**Early**	The seed of a moat not yet defensible on its own
1	**Claimed**	Founder believes it's a moat, but no structural evidence yet

Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Be honest about what you don't know.

If you genuinely can't name a competitor, say so the skill will help you research. If you're not sure if a moat exists, say "I think we might have this, but I'm not certain." Uncertainty is valuable data.

Don't confuse features with moats.

"We have AI" or "we're mobile-first" are features, not moats. Ask yourself: could a well-funded competitor copy this feature in 3–6 months? If yes, it's not a moat.

Think like a skeptical investor.

Imagine an investor asking you to "prove it" when you claim a moat. What proof would you present? Data on customer retention? Estimates of the time to migrate? exclusive data sets? Let the skill drive you on this.

Map substitutes, not just startups.

The biggest “competitor” is often what customers do today, Excel, email, manual processes. If you can’t explain why you’re 10x better than the status quo, your competitive position is weak even if no direct competitor exists.

Revisit this every 6 months.

Your competitive landscape and moats change as you grow. New competitors emerge, moats strengthen (or weaken), and your positioning shifts. Treat this as a living document, not a one-time exercise.

Use it before fundraising.

Investors will ask these questions. Having crisp, evidence-backed answers separates prepared founders from unprepared ones. Run through this skill at least two weeks before your first investor meeting.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to have completed the other skills first?
Not strictly. But this skill builds on Problem Validation (Skill 1), TAM-SAM-SOM (Skill 2), and Beachhead Selection (Skill 3). If you haven’t validated that customers actually have the problem you’re solving, competitive analysis can be misleading, you might be mapping competition for a problem nobody cares about.

What if I genuinely have no competitors?
This is rare and investors will be skeptical. The skill will help you discover substitutes (what customers do today) and potential entrants (who could build this if you succeed). If after thorough research there truly are no competitors, you have either discovered a genuinely new category (exciting but risky) or a problem that isn’t painful enough for others to solve (concerning).

How is this different from just Googling my competitors?
Google shows you who exists. This skill shows you who matters, why they matter, how you’re differentiated, and what makes you defensible. It’s the difference between a list of names and a strategic competitive map with investor-grade moat scoring.

What if my moats are all scored low (1–2)?
That’s normal for early-stage startups. The point isn’t to have perfect moats today, it's to know which moats you’re building toward and what actions will strengthen them. A Score 2 moat with a clear path to Score 4 is better than claiming a Score 5 moat with no evidence.

How long does the conversation take?

About 30 minutes for the full analysis. Faster if you already know your competitors and have thought about moats. Longer if you need to research competitors together or if your market is complex with many player types.

Can I use this for B2C businesses?

The framework works for B2C, but it's optimized for B2B where competitive dynamics, moats, and customer switching costs are easier to articulate. For consumer businesses, network effects and brand moats tend to be more important than switching costs and workflow lock-in.

Is my data private?

Your conversation is between you and Claude. The skill does not store or share your competitive intelligence, moat assessments, or business details with anyone.

Should I share my competitive analysis with investors?

Yes, but be strategic. Include the competitive landscape map and moat scores in your pitch deck. Investors respect founders who understand their competition and can articulate defensibility with evidence. Don't hide weak moats, acknowledge them and show your plan to strengthen them.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial ideas through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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